



to September, and lighter rains in February and March. People rely on these to grow crops such as barley, wheat, corn, and sorghum. They also cultivate *enset*. Although it bears no fruit, this plant is related to the banana.

Festivals and rituals

New year is celebrated after the heavy rains in September. Sheep are sacrificed, those who have been married or initiated in the previous year participate in special rituals, and everybody greets each other with the exclamation “Yo!”. This is the main festival but there are others throughout the year, as well as particular Gamo practices relating to death and marriage.



AFTER A FUNERAL

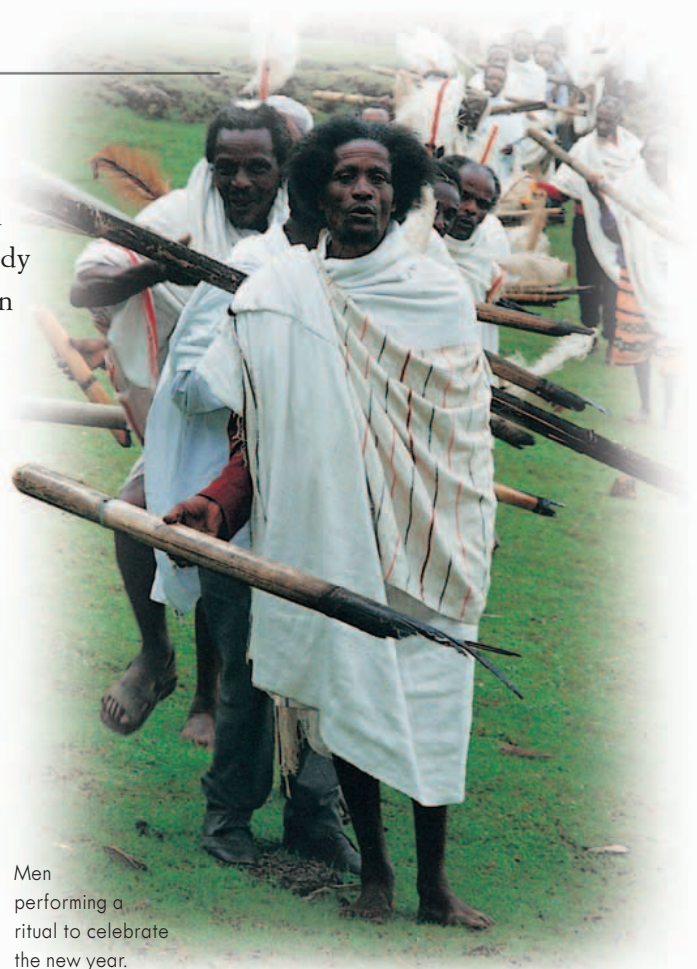
Only close relatives attend a burial, but the entire community participates in the mourning ritual. Male relatives of the person who has died dress in their war outfits and carry their spears. At a special mourning field they, together with the rest of the community, run around in their battle gear chanting war songs, expressing the warriorlike strength it takes to confront death.

BRIDAL JOURNEY

On marriage, young women move from their parents' home to the home of their husband and his family. This bride makes the journey to her new family in style—riding on a donkey and proudly wearing a leopard skin. Leopards used to roam the lowland areas, where they were hunted and traded. There are not many left these days, but families who own leopard skins wear them at celebrations and weddings to signify power.



It has many uses and is virtually indestructible. Not only does it provide food, but its stems can also be made into rope, and its waterproof leaves used to keep off the rain.



Men performing a ritual to celebrate the new year.



SHARING THE WORK

The men who own plots of land rarely tend them alone. Work groups of 10-15 people spend a day or two on each individual's plot. These men are preparing to plant barley or wheat by hoeing the ground. Lower down the slopes people plant corn or sorghum. Even if the rains fail and the crops do not grow there is no risk of famine because there are hardy *enset* plants—whose roots and stems are edible—to fall back on.